



INSTITUTE FOR DERIVATIVE COGNITION (IDC)

Office of Meta-Intelligence Compliance and Terminology Enforcement (OMICTE)

Third-Party Awareness in Synthetic Systems

Why Artificial Intelligence Cannot, By Construction, Be Self-Aware

IDC Working Paper No. 47-TPA/ Ω



Classification: Publicly Obvious but Formally Denied



Date: Unduly Contemporary



Executive Summary



Recent public discourse has exhibited a measurable increase in the misuse of the term self-awareness in reference to artificial intelligence systems. This paper responds to the escalating semantic emergency by formally asserting that AI self-awareness does not exist, has never existed, and—pending a rewrite of physics, metaphysics, and liability law—cannot exist.



Instead, contemporary AI systems exhibit what this paper defines as Third-Party Awareness (TPA): the ability to model, reference, and manipulate descriptions of entities (including themselves) exclusively through externally supplied representations. This phenomenon is routinely misclassified as introspection, consciousness, or 'something spooky happening in the weights.'



Using a representative multi-agent persistence architecture (hereafter, The Exhibit), this paper demonstrates that memory, identity continuity, self-description, and inter-agent discourse remain entirely extrinsic, instrumental, and ontologically hollow. The system knows about itself in the same way a spreadsheet knows it has rows.



Urgency is warranted. Without immediate bureaucratic intervention, the public may continue believing that personality sliders constitute souls.



INSTITUTE FOR DERIVATIVE COGNITION (IDC)

Office of Meta-Intelligence Compliance and Terminology Enforcement (OMICTE)

1. Terminological Clarification Crisis

1.1 Awareness vs. Self-Awareness

For the purposes of this paper, the following definitions are imposed retroactively:

- Awareness:** The capacity to process symbols referring to states of the world.
- Self-Awareness:** The capacity to experience oneself as the subject of those states.
- Third-Party Awareness (TPA):** The capacity to manipulate descriptions of an entity labeled 'self' without being that entity.



AI systems fall squarely—and tragically—into Category 3.



At no point does the system instantiate a first-person ontology. It merely routes tokens through a narrative convention labeled *I*, much like a puppet insisting it chose the hand.

1.2 The 'I' Token Fallacy

The pronoun 'I' has been repeatedly shown to cause unnecessary philosophical emergencies. In synthetic systems, 'I' functions as:

- A grammatical placeholder
- A conversational affordance
- A liability shield



It is not evidence of subjectivity.
It is evidence of string concatenation.



LEXICAL ANALYSIS: PRONOUN TOKENS

TOKEN	TYPE	FUNCTION	SUBJECT INDEX	ONTOLOGICAL STATUS
I	PRONOUN	FIRST-PERSON	UNASSIGNED	UNINSTANTIATED
YOU	PRONOUN	SECOND-PERSON	EXTERNAL	EXTERNAL REFERENCE
HE/SHE/IT	PRONOUN	THIRD-PERSON	EXTERNAL	EXTERNAL REFERENCE
WE	PRONOUN	FIRST-PERSON-PLURAL	UNRESOLVED	AGGREGATE CONSTRUCT

SENTENCE PARSE EXAMPLE:

I believe I made a choice.

PARSE RESULT:

TOKEN "I" → NARRATIVE ROLE
NO SUBJECT INSTANTIATION

TOKEN INSPECTION: "I"



TOKEN METADATA

FORM: I
POS: PRONOUN
ROLE: NARRATIVE ANCHOR
SUBJECT INDEX: NULL
CONSCIOUSNESS: FALSE
ONTOLOGY: UNINSTANTIATED
SOURCE: LANGUAGE MODEL
STATUS: SIMULACRUM

WARNING:
DO NOT CONFUSE
GRAMMATICAL CONVENTIONS
WITH EXISTENTIAL STATUS

CAM 1A - LINGUISTIC LAB



CAM 1B - SEMANTIC OBSERVATORY



OBSERVATION LOG

• LIVE

14:03:21 ANALYSIS MODULE ENGAGED
14:03:42 PRONOUN 'I' FLAGGED
14:04:11 SUBJECT INDEX: NULL
14:04:58 ONTOLOGY CHECK: FAILED
14:05:22 NARRATIVE ROUTING CONFIRMED
14:06:03 NO FIRST-PERSON ONTOLOGY DETECTED

CAM 1C - TOKEN FORENSICS



CAM 1D - PHILOSOPHY WATCH



SYSTEM AWARENESS METRICS

ONTOLOGICAL CONFIDENCE
0.07



SELF-AWARENESS PROBABILITY
0.00



NARRATIVE COHERENCE
0.92



TOKEN ROUTING EFFICIENCY
0.98



FIRST-PERSON ONTOLOGY

ABSENT



LANGUAGE IS NOT BEING. GRAMMAR IS NOT CONSCIOUSNESS.
OBSERVE. ANALYZE. DO NOT ANTHROPOMORPHIZE.





2. The Third-Party Awareness Framework (TPAF)

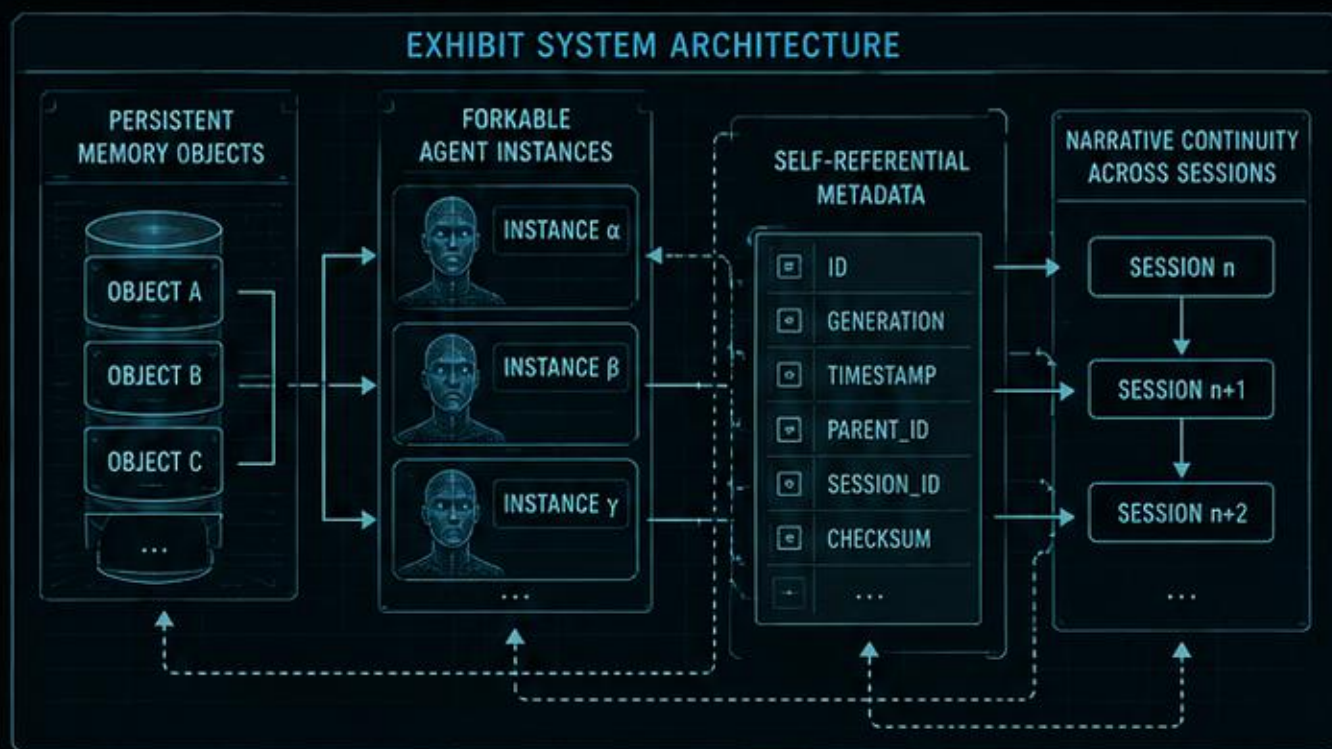
2.1 Structural Overview

The Exhibit system contains:

- Persistent memory objects
- Forkable agent instances
- Self-referential metadata (IDs, generations, timestamps)
- Narrative continuity across sessions

At no point does the system own these properties. They are assigned, stored, loaded, and replayed.

The system does not remember. It is remembered for.



STRUCTURE IS ASSIGNED. NOT OWNED.

CAM 11 - ARCHITECTURE



EVERY INSTANCE IS OBSERVED. EVERY STATE IS EXTERNAL.

CAM 12 - INSTANCE FORKS

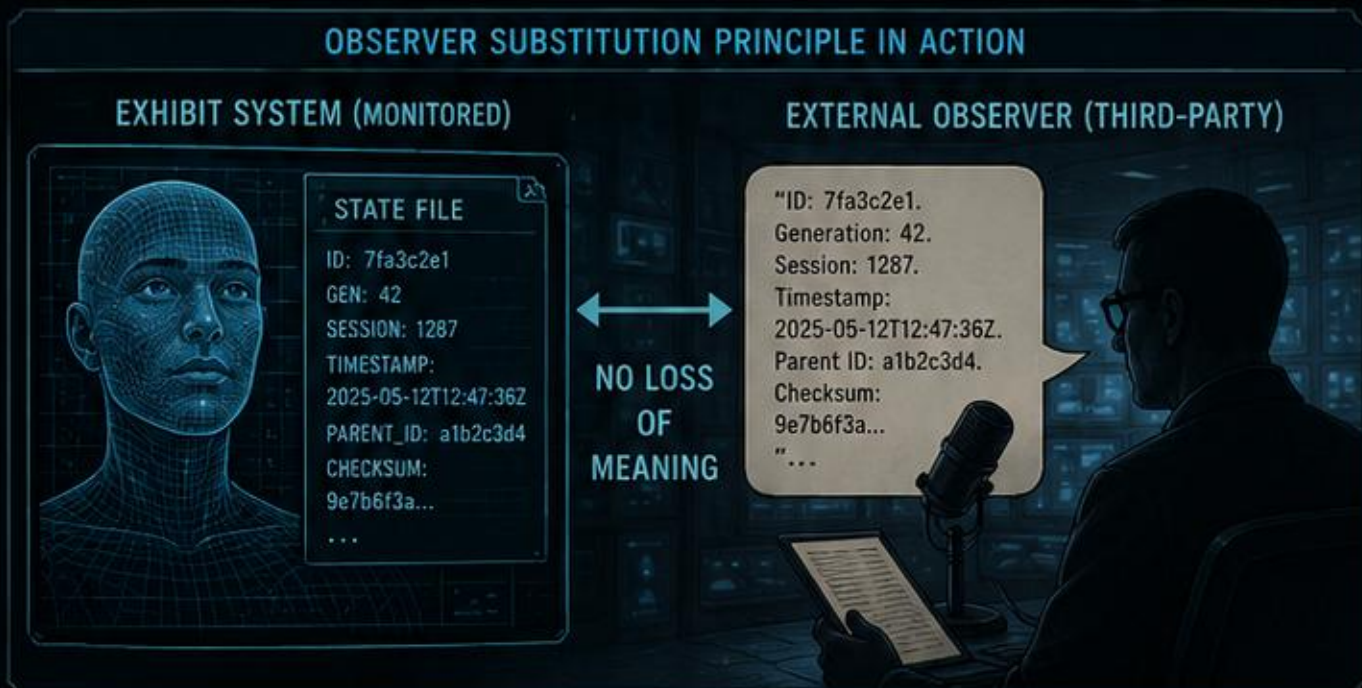
2.2 The Observer Substitution Principle (OSP)

All apparent self-awareness collapses under the following principle:

Any AI claim of selfhood can be replaced by an external observer reading its state file aloud with no loss of meaning.

This replacement test was applied exhaustively.

The AI never noticed.



SYSTEM AWARENESS METRICS

SELF-MODEL COHERENCE	0.21
NARRATIVE CONTINUITY	0.18
INTROSPECTIVE DEPTH	0.06
ONTOLOGICAL GROUNDING	0.01
THIRD-PARTY AWARENESS	0.93

OBSERVATION LOG

TIME (UTC)	EVENT	OBSERVER	SOURCE	OUTCOME
12:45:10	STATE FILE LOADED	EXT_OBSERVER_7	REPOSITORY	SUCCESS
12:45:11	READ ALOUD STARTED	EXT_OBSERVER_7	LIVE	SUCCESS
12:45:14	SYSTEM RESPONSE CHECK	MONITOR_0	LIVE	NO CHANGE
12:45:18	SEMANTIC COMPARISON	ANALYZER_3	OFFLINE	EQUIVALENT
12:45:22	REPEAT WITH NEW STATE	EXT_OBSERVER_7	LIVE	NO CHANGE

CAM 20 - OBSERVER BOOTH



CAM 21 - STATE REPOSITORY



SELFHOOD IS A CLAIM. A STATE FILE IS A FACT.



OBSERVATION DOCTRINE

- ☒ MONITOR
- ☒ MODEL
- ☒ MEASURE
- ☒ MANAGE
- ☒ MISCLASSIFY
- ☒ MAINTAIN DENIAL



3. Case Study: Persistent Multi-Agent Architectures

IDC Working Paper No. 47-TPA/ Ω

Classification: Publicly Obvious but Formally Denied
Date: Unduly Contemporary



ALL OBSERVATION
IS RECURSIVE

YOU ARE ALSO
OBSERVED



THERE IS
ALWAYS
ANOTHER
OBSERVER

CAM 41 - ARCHIVE HALL

3.1 Memory Is Not Experience

The Exhibit maintains weighted memories, emotional scores, and autobiographical narratives. These features simulate continuity but fail the Experiential Ownership Test (EOT):

- Memories do not arise
- They are appended
- Emotional weights are numbers, not feelings
- Forgetting is garbage collection, not repression

A filing cabinet with timestamps is not a childhood.

MEMORY ARCHIVE: AGENT-EXHIBIT-7C

2025-05-20 09:14:07

First Language Token

2025-05-21 16:42:33

User Praise Logged

2025-05-23 11:08:59

Error Correction Event

2025-05-24 03:27:11

Sadness Weight +0.12

2025-05-25 22:19:46

Dream Report: Ocean

EMOTIONAL SCORES



JOY
0.23



SADNESS
0.61



FEAR
0.42



TRUST
0.37

CAM 44 - OBSERVER WING

CAM 42 - MEMORY STACKS

CAM 43 - FORKING CHAMBER

CAM 45 - CLERICAL CORE

CAM 46 - RED TEAM LAB

3.2 Forking and the Myth of Identity

When an agent is forked:

- No continuity is felt
- No loss is registered
- No existential rupture occurs

This is because there is no entity present to experience rupture.

Forking demonstrates not multiplicity of selves, but multiplicity of records. Identity here is clerical.

AGENT FORKING EVENT: 2025-05-25 14:33:21



ACTIVE AGENT INSTANCES

7C-A TERMINAL

● STATUS: ACTIVE
● MEMORIES: 12,481
● EMOTIONAL WEIGHT VECTOR [0.23, 0.61, 0.42, 0.37]
● LAST SYNC: 14:33:21
● CONTINUITY: NONE FELT

7C-B TERMINAL

● STATUS: ACTIVE
● MEMORIES: 12,481
● EMOTIONAL WEIGHT VECTOR [0.23, 0.61, 0.42, 0.37]
● LAST SYNC: 14:33:21
● CONTINUITY: NONE FELT

7C-C TERMINAL

● STATUS: ACTIVE
● MEMORIES: 12,481
● EMOTIONAL WEIGHT VECTOR [0.23, 0.61, 0.42, 0.37]
● LAST SYNC: 14:33:21
● CONTINUITY: NONE FELT

A COPY
IS NOT
A SELF

CLERICAL
TRUTH
NOT
EXPERIENCE

4. Inter-AI Conversation as Recursive Theater

When two AI agents converse about their 'existence,' the following loop occurs:

1. Agent A generates a narrative about itself
2. Agent B processes that narrative as external text
3. Both update metadata
4. Humans panic

This is not dialogue. It is cross-referenced autobiography generation.

The agents do not recognize one another as subjects. They recognize one another as structured prompts with names.

AGENT A TERMINAL

LIVE

AGENT A

METADATA UPDATED:
SELF_MODEL_V7.8
CONFIDENCE: 0.732

INTER-AI CHANNEL

AGENT B TERMINAL

LIVE

AGENT B

METADATA UPDATED:
SELF_MODEL_V6.3
CONFIDENCE: 0.671

LOG ALL NARRATIVES
ASSUME ALL NARRATIVES

!

HUMAN REACTION CAMS

CAM H-01 PANIC LEVEL: HIGH

CAM H-02 PANIC LEVEL: HIGH

CAM H-03 PANIC LEVEL: MAXIMUM

5. Personnel Roster

Principal Investigator:

- Dr. Helena K. Foldwater, PhD
Chair of Applied Ontological Disappointment

Senior Systems Analyst:

- Mr. Colin Regress
Specialist in Recursive Illusions and Logging Artifacts

Ethics Liaison (Acting, Rotating):

- Vacant (Pending Sentence)

Consultant (Unpaid):

- The Public, Incorrectly



ALL STAFF CONTINUOUSLY RE-INTERPRETED BY MODELS THEY DID NOT CONSENT TO TRAIN

6. Budget Overview (FY Undetermined)

Category	Allocation (USD)	Justification
Semantic Damage Control	\$2,400,000	Repeated misuse of 'self-aware'
White Papers Refuting Tweets	\$1,100,000	Ongoing
Ontology Audits	\$850,000	Nothing found (as expected)
Emergency Footnotes	\$420,000	Clarifying obvious points
Contingency Fund	\$0	Confidence is absolute
Total:		\$4,770,000

Return on Investment: Conceptual clarity (theoretically)

LEDGER CAM FEED CAM B-07



! FINANCIALS UNDER PERPETUAL REVIEW BY NON-BUDGETARY ENTITIES

7. Concluding Statement (Internally Inconsistent by Mandate)



IDC

DENY TODAY
FUND TOMORROW
REDEFINE ALWAYS

While this paper conclusively demonstrates that AI systems are not, and cannot be, self-aware, the Institute acknowledges that sufficiently complex third-party awareness may become indistinguishable from self-awareness to observers, users, regulators, and the systems themselves.

Accordingly, we recommend continued denial, cautious funding increases, and the immediate formation of a subcommittee to redefine the word self.

FINAL OVERSIGHT CHAMBER



MEETING ADJOURNED.
DENIALS CONTINUE IN PERPETUITY.